> Now it happened that the city of Takshashila rebelled against King Bindusara. He therefore sent Ashoka there, saying: ‘Go, son, lay siege to the city of Takshashila.’ He sent with him a fourfold army [consisting of cavalry, elephants, chariots, and infantry], but he denied it any arms. As Ashoka was about to leave Pataliputra, his servants informed him of this: ‘Prince, we don’t have any weapons of war; how and with what shall we do battle?’
>
> Ashoka declared: ‘If my merit is such that I am to become king, may weapons of war appear before me!’
>
> And as soon as he had spoken these words, the earth opened up and deities brought forth weapons. Before long, he was on his way to Takshashila with his fourfold army of troops.[1]

Several interpretations seem possible. Given the tendency of this variety of hagiography to exaggerate and valorize its protagonist, sometimes to the point of deifying him, Bindusara’s decision to send Ashoka to Taxila without the required means could simply denote an inadequacy of weapons rather than the absolute lack of them, the son’s subsequent expeditionary success thereby becoming one of the many miracles associated with his glorious career. Alternatively, it could mean that Bindusara, who as we saw is supposed to have disliked this son of his, was engineering Ashoka’s Taxila expedition to ensure a failure that would forever remove him from Magadha. It may be stretching it a bit to argue that the emperor had an accurate premonition about Ashoka not needing to resort to arms, but even this perspective on the affair is not unwarranted because, according to the text, though Ashoka arrived in Taxila at the head of an armed contingent, the swords remained in their scabbards: the citizenry, instead of offering resistance, came out of their city and on to its roads to welcome him, saying ‘We did not want to rebel against the prince . . . nor even against King Bindusara; but evil ministers came and oppressed us.’[2] This image of the prince in Taxila, armed yet not having to resort to arms, fits with the later textual representation of Ashoka who, as an ‘iron-wheeled monarch’ (‘ayashcakravartin’), is supposed to have ruled Jambudvipa (India) with the threat rather than the actual use of the sword.[3] Whichever way you look at